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Where Is South Heights?

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In the southeastern corner of Hopewell Township, in South Side Beaver County lies the small borough of South Heights. The Ohio River is along the waterfront on east side, and to the south is the Allegheny County line. Chartered in 1910, the town was formerly called Shannopin, of native Delaware origin as shown on a Beaver County map dated 1886.

Because the borough was zoned residential, with low taxes, it became necessary for South Heights to join the Ambridge School District so the children had to be bussed across the river to attend school.

If the borough lacks industry, it is surrounded by former large manufacturing works such as: the Jones and Laughlin Steel Co., north whose works stretched seven miles along the Ohio and employed 14,000 in the 1970's; across the river the U.S. Steel Company's American Bridge Division, touted to be the largest steel fabricator in the world. They made steel structures for tall buildings, bridges and built towboats by the hundreds and dozens of LST's; in 1979 they launched their 5000th barge. At the eastern corner is the now closed Phillips Power Generating Plant owned by Duquesne Light Company. It was a coal burning operation, and coal was brought to the plant via river barges. The nuclear and steam generating plants in Shippingport. replaced these older coal installations.

Jordan Street is the town's main thoroughfare, also State Route 51, a wide tree-lined avenue with sidewalks. The business section along Rt. 51 has three establishments which constitute their "downtown" - - Creswell Heights Joint Authority (water), the Post Office and the South Heights Super. Other businesses are scattered among residences on Jordan St. Most of the residences are up on the steep western hillside back of town, served by roads that contour their way to the ridge top in Hopewell

Township. Some of the homes have nice views of the river valley and the parade of mills and heavy shops lining the river side.

Back in 1873-77 The Pittsburgh and Lake Erie Railroad of Pittsburgh were surveying the western side of the Ohio River valley for a railroad right-of-way. A great shelving out was required to place trackage, and culverts were installed or steel girder trestles were placed over the numerous runs and creeks. The first passenger train came through on February 27, 1879. The popularity of railroad shipping made it necessary ultimately to expand to four tracks wide.

By 1885 oil and gas wells were being drilled on the South Side. A small field of oil and gas came in at Gringo, about two miles west of Shannopin, which created an oil fever and boom times for a while. A nitroglycerine factory was built up one of the ravines back of town. Nitro was a chemical product used in wells to be detonated at the well bottom to fracture the rock surrounding the bottom cavity, thereby releasing more oil. Sometimes an oil pocket was struck and the oil gushed up out of the well. In the early days the oil flowed to the nearest creek. Later earthen pits were dug until tanks could be built, and then pipe lines.

Ralph Fife, a friend of mine, told me he used to ride with his mother to deliver nitroglycerine in a wagon. They had a compartmented box filled with cotton to avoid jolts which could detonate the nitro. The box was suspended with springs under the wagon seat. In 1897 the first nitroglycerine plant blew up, and the workers were mutilated. Locks in Ambridge homes were blown off doors, windows shattered, and the papers said the concussion was felt as far away as Wilkinsburg and Homestead.

Probably most of the residents now are retirees from the above-named companies and working people who are proud to call South Heights "My Home Town".